

WESTERN DIGITAL - INTERNSHIP

About the Company

Western Digital is a major data storage company with a legacy of innovation, evolving from its 1970 founding as a semiconductor maker to become a leader in hard disk drives (HDDs) and flash memory solutions for consumers, businesses, and cloud providers. Its long history includes a strategic pivot to focus on data storage technologies, leading to breakthroughs like OptiNAND and a continued commitment to developing reliable, high-capacity storage for the growing digital world. Western Digital has its only Indian office at Bangalore.

Eligible Branches:	CSE, EEE, ECE
Eligibility Criteria:	7.5 and above from 10th onwards, No history of arrear.
Internship Location:	Bangalore
Internship Duration:	8 weeks
Stipend:	Rs. 40,000
Roles:	Software Engineer (Embedded), Platform Engineer

Selection Process

1. Initial screening by Resume
2. Online Assessment
3. Interviews
 - a. Technical Interviews
 - b. HR Interviews

Initial screening based on Resume

From the applied candidates there was an initial screening with respect to resume and CGPA. It was not mentioned on what basis the resumes were screened although it was probably based on whether the candidate knows C/C++. I had a simple C++ project in my resume and included C and C++ in the languages known.

Online Assessment

Duration: 40 mins

Location: CUIC

The OA was conducted at CUIC Labs on the Hirepro website. Ensure your microphone and cameras are working properly if you are taking the assessment on your laptop.

Software Engineer (Embedded)

30 Aptitude Questions on numerical aptitude and general logical reasoning. The questions were not too hard.

Platform Engineer

Apart from the aptitude questions also included a segment with 20 coding MCQs based on C and C++. Although I did not attempt this assessment I heard that it was not too difficult.

10 were shortlisted for the Software Engineer Embedded role and 30 for the Platform Engineer role from CEG and MIT.

Interviews

Technical Interview 1

Duration: 1 Hour Location: CUIC

I was assigned to an online interview although many had offline.

Non-technical Questions asked:

1. Why did you pick CEG and why CSE?
2. Why are you interested in joining Western Digital?
3. Your projects are not very related to the work here. So, why did you pick this role?
4. If you had to pick between these in a decade's time what would you pick: Domain expert, a project manager, technical manager, general expert.
5. What choice would you take between masters or placements and why?

For the non-technical questions it's purely based on how you weave a convincing story. I myself had not explored much in embedded programming but tried to use smaller experiences like switching to a linux OS and using the Raspberry PI.

I was asked what my favourite subjects were and I said DSA and Computer Architecture and hence was asked questions on DSA. I was also asked if I knew OS and mentioned that I was currently learning that.

Technical Questions:

1. Find the 2nd maximum element in the array
(<https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/dsa/find-second-largest-element-array/>)
2. Find the kth maximum element in the array
(<https://leetcode.com/problems/kth-largest-element-in-an-array/description/>)

I was asked to type out the code in notepad and was also asked to implement some in-built functions like max(a,b)

For this I was not asked to code it but to only give the logic. I had given an approach of using bucket sort for $O(n)$ time and space as well as a heap based method for $O(n \log k)$ time. I had not mentioned QuickSelect which is the most efficient algorithm capable of solving this in $O(n)$ time and constant space.

3. Explain some of the scheduling algorithms in OS.

The interviewer wanted to know if I had any questions and asked the following:

1. How has AI affected your workflow?

I was told that I wasn't selected for the next round in the interviews for Software Engineer Embedded but was suggested for Platform Engineer and was asked to sit for those interviews. (I am not sure why this was done but yes I had to sit for another series of interviews with a lot of people already in the queue.)

Technical Interview 2

Duration: 30 mins Location: CUIC

This interview was for the Platform Engineer role. As I had already done an interview before there weren't many non-technical questions asked in this round.

Technical Questions:

1. Find if a linked list has a cycle
(<https://leetcode.com/problems/linked-list-cycle/description/>)
I was asked to write the full code on paper in either C or C++.
2. Reverse words in a string
(<https://leetcode.com/problems/reverse-words-in-a-string/description/>)

I was again asked to write the full code on paper and was asked to do the reversal in-place.

Techno-HR Interview

This was a relaxed interview focussed on follow-ups based on my answers to questions.

Things i talked about:

1. Experience in projects and difficulties faced.
2. My exploration of embedded programming and electronics (I had once broken my hard drive and tried to replace it back so I talked about that.)
3. Leadership experiences in clubs
4. Why Western Digital?

I was then given the opportunity to ask questions to the interviewer and I asked the following:

1. How has AI affected the products you make?
2. Do you feel there is a market for developing AI products for internal use in companies?
3. Why is WD focussed primarily on HDDs? Are SSDs a viable option for enterprise storage?

HR Interview

Duration: 10 mins

Location: CUIC

This was a quick round asking about my family background, my siblings, whether relocation to Bangalore would be an issue and about my experiences in clubs focussing on leading diverse teams.

I was then selected for the Platform Engineer role along with 4 other MIT students and for the role of Software Engineer (Embedded) 3 were selected.

Some tips:

1. Try to pick a practice sheet for DSA quickly, I spent more time researching the best sheet than doing actual questions initially. Pick neetcode 150 or Striver A2Z. Also try to start practice during the 4th sem starting itself so that you can take a more relaxed learning approach. (It is tiring to try and do 5-6 problems a day at the end).
2. Understand patterns and not just solutions. I initially tried to remember solutions and yes for some you just HAVE to remember but for many you can try understanding the pattern. Try to explain each step you take towards the solution (e.g. Why should this pointer move to the right , why try sorting this first and so on), doing so will make it easier to find patterns in unseen questions. Try to also not jump straight into coding a question after you see it; explain to yourself the logic behind your solution, that way you can start identifying loop holes.
3. When asked what your favourite subject is, try to answer something related to the job description. Answering Full Stack Technology for a WD interview is not suitable as they don't really do much of full stack. Try to tune your resume also similarly if possible.
4. Ensure you know all of the things mentioned in your resume. Your resume doesn't have to be groundbreaking. A good and suitable set of projects (2-3), tools, languages related to the job, leadership experience if any and certifications and workshops can fill your resume.
5. Please also practice aptitude. Aptitude is asked in almost all OAs and usually people skip out on that.
6. Go through CS subjects like DBMS, OOPS, OS (if already done), C and C++.
7. Be confident while speaking, you do not have to know everything beforehand, try to use whatever knowledge you have and tackle the questions.

Do not chase number of leetcode/DSA questions and try to understand them. I had to redo 150 questions because I forgot all of them. You might face rejections along the way, do not worry about that at the end you only need 1 internship.

Luck plays a major role and is often overlooked but unfortunately you cannot practice luck so do not worry if you are unlucky and be grateful if you are.

Try your level best and leave the rest. Try to get an internship if not you can always try for placements.

Do not stress out too much or you will get hairfall (and that is worse than not getting an intern).

May the force be with you!

Reach out if you have any doubts whatsoever :D

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